

3 ALWAYS AMBIVALENT

Displayed the same ambivalence when he quit as party president in 2005 after being at the receiving end of Jinnah controversy. He withdrew his resignation, only to exit under pressure from the RSS.

4 PRIME MISCALCULATION

Advani's attacks on the prime minister during the election boomeranged. The voters were clearly not pleased with the affable, non-controversial Singh being the prime target. The BJP suffered and Advani's image took a beating.

5 JASWANT AND JINNAH

Opened himself to charges of being weak and opportunist when he failed to speak up for his longest-standing associate Jaswant Singh, and was party to the decision to expel him for writing a book in praise of Jinnah.

one, he saw it as a moment of liberation and possibility. He should have stopped there. Instead, the *yatri* accelerated his pace only to become the cause number one of the BJP's nervous breakdown.

THE BETRAYAL IN SHIMLA

The overwhelming truth today is that there is no recovery as long as he remains the highest deity. He is the one who stands between decay and renewal. After the 2004 defeat, at the National Council meeting of the party, he said: "Ideology is what gives the BJP its distinctive identity. We are a party with a difference precisely because we are firmly wedded to a set of core beliefs. Our political priorities, strategies and tactics may be fashioned by the issues of the day but our ideology remains constant. The BJP is first and foremost a nation-first party. We are a party of nationalism. Our politics is determined by the litmus test of what is good and desirable for the nation." Those were inspiring—and reassuring—words from the original action hero of Hindutva, which he had defined as a nationalist, not religious, sentiment. And those words should have formed the first testament of the party's new guide and philosopher. He should have gracefully made the way for a new leader. He had other ideas, and there was a job he badly wanted. He chose to be the highest guru of subterranean manipulations, and defying both biology as well as ideology, he repainted himself as the Future. He did not become another Vajpayee. He has become the sole repudiator of whatever the great reconciler of the Indian Right stands for.

Not that it was too late for him to play the wise counsellor. Shimla—or in retrospect Jaswant Singh's Siberia—



AFP PHOTO/AMIR QURESHI

ADVANI SHOULD HAVE GRACEFULLY MADE THE WAY FOR A NEW LEADER

ADVANI'S EXCESSIVE DEPENDENCE ON THE FAVOURED troika eroded his neutrality, authority and consequently his acceptability among other leaders in the party.